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PSY 711 — Past Questions & Materials

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Paper 1 of 1 — PSY 711 Introduction To Psychology Past Question

Level 100 • First Semester • PastQuestion

DAPRTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY

FACULTY OF SOCIAL SCIENCES

NASARAWA STATE UNIVERSITY, KEFFI

PSY711 - INTRODUCTION TO PSYCHOLOGY

LECTURE GUIDE

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PSY111 - INTRODUCTION TO PSYCHOLOGY

COURSE SYNOPSES

This entails a brief history of psychology, definition and fields of psychology as well as methods of investigation. The course focuses attention on the introductory discourse of pertinent areas of General Psychology such as perception and sensation, motivation, Psychology in human growth and development.

COURSE OUTLINES

- i. Introduction
- ii. Goals of psychology
- iii. Fields of psychology
- iv. Relationships between psychology and other Disciplines
- v. Schools of thought in psychology- Behaviourism, Psychoanalysis, Gestalt, Cognitive, Humanistic etc
- vi. Motivation
- vii. Memory
- viii. Personality
- ix. Learning
- x. Stress and coping.

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INTRODUCTION

Psychology as a discipline is as old as mankind. Viewing from history, psychology began from the onset of creation when God created Adam and after sometimes, He discovered that Adam was having some emotional problems and created a wife for him to cusion his emotional problems. God himself is the Father of Psychology.

Psychology formally was studied under philosophy but with a building of experimental laboratory at University of Leipzig, Germany by Whilhem Wundt in 1879. Psychology began to be a study of its own.

Psychology was introduced in Nigeria in 1964 at the University of

Nigeria, Nsukka. Today, we have over 60 psychology Departments in Nigeria.

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DEFINITIONS

Many scholars defined psychology in various perspectives. Psychology is defined as the scientific study of human and animal behavior, both covert and overt ones including normal and abnormal behavior through systematic experimentation in the laboratory.

Psychology is the science that seeks to understand behavior and to apply that understanding in the service of human welfare.

Another definition is that psychology is the science of behavior and mental processes. Note that this definition contains three key terms – science, behavior and mental processes.

a. Psychology is considered a science because psychologists attempt to understand people by thinking critically about careful, controlled observations. This reliance on rigorous scientific methods of observation is the basis of all science.

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b. The term behavior refers to all of a person's overt actions that others can directly observe. When you talk, speak or frown, you are behaving in this sense.

c. The term mental processes refer to private thoughts, emotions, feelings and motives that other people cannot directly observe.

GOALS OF PSYCHOLOGY

There are basically four goals that psychology tries to achieve in our daily interactions.

a. Describing – the first goal of psychology is to observe and describe behavior. Differentiating between normal, healthy and unhealthy behaviours is the cornerstone of psychology, so it is important that psychologists have a keen sense of observation. Not only does the psychologists have to observe one's actions but also his or her attitudes, feelings, goals, motivations, reactions and thoughts to the best of his or her abilities. In addition to observation, psychologists have

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to use other methods to describe behavior including case studies, correlation studies, surveys and other testing.

b. Explaining – the attempt to explain behavior based on observation is actually rather difficult due to many factors. For

instance, behavior varies among culture and can change over time. An acceptable behavior in one culture may not be acceptable in another. Furthermore, as the world continues to expand (or grow smaller) through the use of technology, transferring acceptable modes of behaviour to new technology can become confusing or create new modes of behavior.

c. Predicting – the third goal of psychology is to predict behavior. Psychologists try to determine if a person is likely to make healthy or unhealthy decisions when confronted with certain situations. Most of the time, they will use experiments to make their predictions. A subject

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can be placed in an environment and given a stimulus or stimuli to see how he or she will perform. Sometimes, a psychologist will look at past behavior in order to predict. In any case, predictions can sometimes be wrong.

d. Influencing Behaviour – This can be to change unhealthy behavior as well as encourage already existing healthy behavior. There are so many methods used to influence behavior such as positive reinforcement or rewarding good behavior.

Although the goals of psychology are universally the same, many psychologists will go about achieving these goals in different ways. Furthermore, they have to keep in mind that there are always exceptions. In other words, sometimes, the behavior of a group does not necessarily mean that an individual that fits into that group will behave in a consistent manner and vice versa. However, psychology can be a useful tool despite its limitations to predict and prevent destructive behavior and reinforce healthy and positive attitudes and behaviors.

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BRANCHES OF PSYCHOLOGY

There are so many branches of subfield of psychology. Psychologists specializes in these areas and render services as the need arise.

a. Biological Psychology – this field is also called physiological psychology. Psychologists use high tech scanning devices and other methods to study how biological processes in the brain and other organs affect and are affected by behavior and mental processes.

b. Developmental Psychology – this field describes change in behavior and mental processes from birth through old age and tries to understand the causes and effects of those changes.

c. Cognitive Psychology – Cognitive psychologists study mental

abilities such as sensation and perception, learning and memory, thinking, consciousness, intelligence and creativity.

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d. Personality Psychology – This area studies similarities and differences among people. Some of them use tests, interviews and other measures to compare individuals on characteristics such as openness to experience, emotionality, reliability, agreeableness and sociability. They also study the characteristics of people who are prejudicial against others who tend to be pessimistic or depressed.

e. Clinical Psychology – Clinical Psychologists conduct research on the causes of mental disorders and offer services to help troubled people overcome these disorders. They found for example, that many irrational fears, called Phobias, are learned through the bad experiences people have with dogs, public speaking or whatever, and fearful people can literally be taught to overcome their fears.

f. Community Psychology – They try to ensure that psychological services reach the homeless and others who need help but tend not to seek it. They also try to prevent psychological disorders by working for changes in schools or neighborhood organizations

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in hopes of reducing poverty and other stressful conditions that so often lead to disorders.

g. Health Psychology – Health psychologists study the effects of behavior on health, as well as the effects illness has on people's behavior and emotions.

h. Educational and School Psychology – Educational psychologists conduct research and develop theories about teaching and learning. The results of their work are applied in programs designed to improve teacher training, refine school curriculum, reduce dropout rates and help students learn more efficiently. On the other hand, school psychologists traditionally specialized in IQ testing, diagnosing learning disabilities and other academic problems and setting up programs to improve student's achievement and satisfaction in school.

i. Industrial/Organizational Psychology – The psychologists here study leadership, stress, competition, pay scales and other factors that affect the efficiency, productivity and satisfaction of workers and the organizations that employ them. They conduct

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research on topics such as increasing the motivation of current

employees and helping companies select the best new workers.

j. Social Psychology – This study the ways that people think about themselves and others and how people influence one another. Their research helps us in preventing the spread of AIDS and also in promoting the use of seatbelts. They also assist us in determining whom we like or love and why people form different groups.

k. Environmental Psychology – This area is concern with the study of the effects of the environment on people's behavior and the mental processes. The results of their research are applied by architects and interior designers as they plan or remodel residence, halls, shopping malls, auditoriums, hospitals, prisons, offices and other spaces to make them more comfortable and function for the people who will occupy them.

l. Forensic Psychology – They assist in jury selection, evaluate dependant's mental competence to stand trial and deal with other issues involving psychology and law.

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m. Sport Psychology – They use visualization and relaxation training programs, for example, to help athletes reduce excessive anxiety, focus attention and other changes that let them perform at their best.

SCHOOLS OF THOUGHT IN PSYCHOLOGY

Psychology which means the study of the mind is an enormous field. Several schools of thought in psychology were established by the early psychologists according to their respective modes of research and study. These include several approaches to this social science.

Although, different schools of thought in psychology have disputed for a particular model to be used as a guiding theory so as to explain the human behavior, some psychologists tend to adhere to a particular school of thought and reject the others. But almost all psychologists consider each as an approach to understanding the mind. Here are some major schools of thought in psychology.

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1. Biological Perspective – The psychological model behind this school of thought in psychology studies the role of biological functioning to shape the behavior, thus pronouncing the realm of the biological perspective.
2. Psychodynamic Perspective – Sigmund Freud was the founder of this approach. This model believes that human behavior is controlled by inner feelings (forces) over the individual has little power

and has little awareness. This school of thought in psychology lay emphasis on the influence of the unconscious mind on behavior.

3. Cognitive Psychology – This school of thought in psychology is based on the notion that behavior is controlled by the way we know, comprehend and reflect the world. This branch of psychology studies mental processes including how people think, recognizes, remember and learn.

4. Behavioural Perspective – This model believes that the external surrounding and environmental causes is the major factor in shaping the behavior of an individual. Behaviorist became the

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main school of thought in psychology during the 1950s.

5. Humanistic Perspective – Under this school of thought in psychology, people have full control over their lives and are solely accountable for shaping their thoughts, ideas, behavior and attitude. This perspective developed as a response to psychoanalysis and behaviorism.

6. Gestalt Perspective – This perspective or approach to psychology has its origin in Germany and Austria during the late 19th century. According to the gestalt thinkers, the whole is much bigger and superior than the sum of its part and one must look at the whole of experience, rather than splitting down the thoughts and behavior to their smallest units.

RELATIONSHIPS BETWEEN PSYCHOLOGY AND OTHER DISCIPLINES

Psychology is the study of behavior but the study of behavior is not exclusive in other behavioral sciences. Other discipline also study behavior that is why they are called behavioral sciences. In psychology we study the individuals and STATE

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factors concern the behavior, factors within the individual that also influence the behavior.

Sociology also study behavior but study in group that is the study of the society as a whole.

Social anthropology is interested in human behavior especially how the behavior is in the past and compares it with the modern behavior in the group. The differences between psychology and social anthropology is that social anthropology study in groups and how past behavior affect the

present.

Economics is the study of distribution of goods and how changes in economy affect the man and his environment in order to survive and also where those things are achieved and when it meets the demand of the people.

Political science is the study of behavior and voting system, behavior is influence by the events of society or country. One's behavior is as a result of a societal belief like voting where everyone is expected to vote. As psychologist is to advise the government so that there would

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be enough security and people will not involve in violent act. Political election has a political behavior.

Psychology and philosophy are also related. Philosophy is the study of knowledge, reality and existence.

Psychology is also related to education. Psychology tries to find out ways of improving learning, how you can teach one to obtain knowledge. This is done by using materials to conscientize the person in the case of children, but in the case of adult, all these materials are indication of imparting knowledge to you. Education is interested in how to change individual behavior towards learning by improving one's learning cognitively and emotionally.

Psychology also has relationship with the natural sciences eg Physics, Biology, Chemistry.

Psychology is also related to medicine. It is believe that some medical conditions are to due to psychological effect eg feeling very sad which after sometime result to low or high blood pressure. Sometimes we

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don't behave normally due to frustration caused by stress.

Geography is another important area that deals with psychology. As we know Geography is the study of both physical and natural environments and how these affect man. Problems of flood, environmental degradation, erosion are concern of geographers. So they use knowledge of psychology to see how man can adapt and adjust with these environmental pressures.

PERSONALITY

Personality is the person's unique and relatively stable behavior pattern. It is a unique and distinctive characteristic which set a person apart from others.

Personality is made of up of the characteristic patterns of thoughts, feelings and behaviors that make a person unique. In addition to this, personality arises from within the individual and remains fairly consistent throughout life.

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Some of the fundamental characteristic of personality includes:

- a. Consistency – There is generally a recognizable order and regularity to behavior. Essentially, people act in a variety of situations.
- b. Psychological and physiological – Personality is a psychological construct, but research suggests that it is also influenced by biological processes and needs.
- c. It impacts behaviors and actions – Personality does not just influence how we move and respond in our environment, it also causes us to act in certain ways.
- d. Multiple expressions – personality is displayed in more than just a behavior. It can also be seen in our thoughts, feelings, close relationships and other social interactions.

SIGMUND FREUD'S PERSONALITY

This personality according to Freud is called psychodynamic theories of personality which emphasize the influence of the unconscious on personality. He believed that all humans have three sets of personality

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which include id, ego and superego.

Id – according to Freud, the id is the primitive part of personality which is unconscious that supply energies and demand for immediate gratifications.

Ego – is the executive part of personality that controls rational behaviors.

Superego – is that part of personality that serves a morals ie it guides the individual to behave in a socially acceptable fashion.

PSYCHOSEXUAL STAGES OF DEVELOPMENT

Freud believed that there to be five stages of psychosexual development: oral, anal, phallic, latency and genital. At each of these stages, pleasure is focused on a particular part of the body. Too much or too little pleasure in any one of these stages caused a fixation which would lead to personality or psychological disorders. For example, too much pleasure in phallic stage could lead to obsessive masturbation and sexual dysfunction as an adult.

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- a. Oral Stage – this is characterized by a preoccupation with oral pleasures such as nursing and sucking. The child uses the mouth as a source of pleasure.
- b. Anal Stage – this is where the main focus is on eliminating or

retaining faces. The child is learning how to use the toilet.

c. Phallic Stage – this is where children derive pleasure from the genitals and develop a desire for the opposite sex parent. Society dictates that these inappropriate feelings be repressed.

d. Latency Stage – this is the stage where all sexual feelings are repressed i.e. lie dormant until the child reaches adult life.

e. Genital Stage – this is where the sexual desires is reawakened and are directed towards peers of the opposite sex. At each stage, conflicts come to a successful resolution otherwise it results in fixations that may cause psychological problems in the future.

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LEARNING

As human being, we come into the world with no experience ie we don't know anything around us. But in the course of our growing up, we come to know what happens in our environment through learning.

Learning is also acquisition of new or modifying existing knowledge, behaviors, skills, values and preferences and involves synthesizing different types of information. The ability to learn is possessed by humans, animals and some machines. Progress over time tends to follow learning curves: learning is not compulsory; it is contextual. It does not happen at once, but builds upon and is shaped by what we already know. To that end, learning may not be viewed as a process, rather than a collection of factual and procedural knowledge.

Human learning may occur as part of education, personal development, schooling or training. It may be goal oriented and may be aided by motivation. The study of how learning occurs is part of neuropsychology, educational psychology, learning theory. Learning

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may occur as a result of habituation or classical conditioning seen in many animal species or as a result of more complex activities such as play, seen only in relatively intelligent animals. Learning may occur consciously or without conscious awareness.

TYPES

1. Associative learning – is the process by which an association between two stimuli or a behavior and a stimulus is learned. The two forms of associative learning are classical and operant conditioning.

2. Observational learning – is learning by observation. The learning process mostly occurs through imitation, one's personal repetition of observed behavior such as dance. Human can copy three types of information simultaneously: the demonstrator's goals, actions

and environmental outcomes. Through copying these will tune into surrounding culture.

3. Play – play generally describes behavior which has no particular end in itself, but improves performance in similar situations in the

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future. This is seen in a wide variety of vertebrates besides humans, but is mostly limited to animals and birds. Cats are known to play with a ball of string when young, which gives them experience with catching prey.

Play as it pertains to human as a form of learning is central to a child's learning and development. Through play, children learn social skills such as sharing and collaboration. Children develop emotional skills such as learning to deal with the emotion of anger through play activities. As a form of learning, play also facilitates the development of thinking and language skills in children. Play consists of:

- a. Sensori motor play also known as functional play, characterized by repetition of activity.
- b. Role play – this occurs from 3 to 15 years of age.
- c. Rule -based play – where authoritative prescribed codes of conduct are primary.
- d. Construction play – involves experimentation and building.

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- e. Movement plays also known as physical play.

These types of play often intersected. All types of play generate thinking and problem-solving skills in children. Children learn to think creatively when they learn through play.

MOTIVATION

Motivation is a psychological feature that arouses an organism to action toward a desired goal, the reason for the action. Motivation is the driving force which causes to achieve goals. Motivation is said to be intrinsic and extrinsic. The term is generally used for humans but, theoretically, it can also be used to describe the causes for animal behavior as well.

Motivation may be rooted in a basic need to minimize physical pain and maximize pleasure, or it may include specific needs such as eating and resting or a desired object, goal, state of being, deal, or it may be attributed to less apparent reasons such as altruism, selfishness,

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morality or avoiding mortality.

Motivation is divided into

1. Intrinsic Motivation – this refers to motivation that is driven by an interest or enjoyment in the task itself and exist within the individual rather than relying on any external pressure. This has been studied by social and educational psychologists since the 1970s and research has found out that it is usually associated with high educational achievement and enjoyment by students. Students are likely to be intrinsically motivated if they: attribute their educational results to internal factors that they can control (the amount of effort they put in), believe they can be effective agents in reaching a desired goals (ie the results are not determined by luck), are interested in mastering a topic, rather than just rote- learning to achieve good grades.

2. Extrinsic Motivation – this comes from outside of the individual. Common extrinsic motivations are rewards like money and grades, coercion and threat of punishment. Competition is in general extrinsic
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because it encourages the performer to win and beat others, not to enjoy the intrinsic rewards of the activity. Social psychological research has indicated that extrinsic rewards can lead to over justification and a subsequent reduction in intrinsic activity.

THEORIES OF MOTIVATION

Several theories has been highlighted to explain motivation some of which includes:

1. Maslow theory of motivation – Abraham H Maslow believes that human beings have certain inborn needs which they strive to fulfill. He describes human needs in biological terms. To Maslow, every need arises from an imbalance or disequilibrium between what human nature deems necessary for the health of a person and what a person's environment provides.

Maslow proposed five types of human needs in a hierarchy which reflects the sequence in which needs must be fulfilled.

a. Physiological needs – food, drinks, hunger, thirst and shelter.

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b. Safety needs – to feel secure and safe, to be protected out of danger.

c. Love and belonging needs: to affiliate with others, be personally accepted.

d. Self Esteem needs: to achieve, be competent, gain self respect, prestige, independence and freedom, social status, approval and recognition.

e. Self actualization needs: self fulfillment, self achievement of

personal goals, ambitions and potentials.

A need is the lack of something that if present would further the welfare of the organism.

There are primary and secondary needs. Primary or innate basic physiological needs include food, appetite, water and oxygen, hunger and thirst, rest, protection, sexual union, regular elimination of excretory products from the body, escape from pain, release from anxiety and other disturbing emotional states. Secondary needs are learned e.g. affection, aggression, autonomy, dominance etc.

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2. Incentive theory – a reward, tangible or intangible, is presented after the occurrence of an action (ie behaviour) with the intent to cause the behaviour to occur again. This is done by associating positive meaning to the behaviour. Studies show that if the person receives the reward immediately, the effect would be greater and decreases as duration lengthens.

From this point of view, people behave in order to get positive incentives and avoid negative incentives. Incentive theory is promoted by behavioural psychologists such as B F Skinner. Incentive theorists tend to distinguish between wanting and liking, where liking is a passive function evaluating a stimulus but wanting adds an active process “attracting” the person towards the stimulus.

3. Drive – Reduction Theory – this grows out of the concept that we have certain biological drives such as hunger. As time passes the strength of the drives increases if it is not satisfied (in this case by eating). Upon satisfying a drive the drive’s strength is reduced.

The theory is based on diverse ideas from the theories of Freud to

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the ideas of feedback control systems such as thermostat. Drive theory has some intuitive or folk validity. According to this theory, an imbalance in homeostasis creates a need – a biological requirement for wellbeing.

The brain responds to such needs by creating a psychological state called – a drive – a feeling of arousal that prompts an organism to take action, restore the balance, and as a result, reduce the drive. For example, if you have had no water for sometime, the chemical balance of your body fluids is disturbed, creating a biological need for water. After you drink, the need for water is met, so the drive is reduced.

4. Cognitive Dissonance Theory – suggested by Leon Festinger, who maintained that this occurs when an individual experiences some degree of discomfort resulting from an incompatibility between two

cognitions. For example, a consumer may seek to reassure himself regarding a purchase, feeling, in retrospect, that another decision may have been preferable. Another example of cognitive dissonance is when a belief and behaviour are in

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conflict. A person may wish to be healthy, believes smoking is bad for one's health and yet continues to smoke.

5. Alderfer's ERG Theory – Alderfer expanding on Maslow's hierarchy of needs, created the EGR theory. This theory posits that there are three groups of core needs – existence, relatedness and growth, hence the label: ERG theory. The existence group is concerned with providing our basic material existence requirements. They include the items that Maslow considered to be physiological and safety needs. The second group of needs are those of relatedness – the desire we have for maintaining important interpersonal relationships. These social and status desires require interaction with others if they are to be satisfied, and they align with Maslow's social need and the external component of Maslow's esteem classification. Finally, Alderfer isolates growth needs an intrinsic desire for personal development. These include the intrinsic component from Maslow's esteem category and the characteristics included under self actualization.

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MEMORY

1. The faculty by which the mind stores and remembers information.
2. Something remembered from the past, a recollection
3. The part of a computer in which data or program instructions can be stored for retrieval.

Memory is our ability to encode, store, retain and subsequently recall information and past experiences in the human brain. It can be thought of in general terms as the use of past experience to affect or influence current behaviour.

Memory is the sum total of what we remember, and gives us the capability to learn and adapt from previous experiences as well as build relationship. It is the ability to remember past experiences, and the power or process of recalling to mind previously learned facts, experiences, impressions, skills and habits. It is the store of things learned and retained from our activity or experience, as evidenced by modification of structure or behaviour, or by recall a recognition.

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In more physiological and neurological terms, memory is, at its simplest,

a set of encoded neural connections in the brain. It is the recreation or reconstruction of past experiences by synchronous firing of neurons that were involved in the original experience.

The sociological concept of collective memory plays an essential role in establishment of human societies. Every social group perpetuates itself through the knowledge that it transmit down the generations, either through oral tradition or through writing. The invention of writing made it possible for the first time for human beings to preserve precise records of the knowledge outside of their brains. Writing, audiovisual media and computer records can be considered a kind of external memory for humans.

TYPES

Memory can be broadly divided into three:

1. Sensory memory – this is the shortest element of memory. It is the ability to retain impressions of sensory information after the original stimuli have ended. It acts as a kind of buffer for stimuli

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received through the five senses of sight, hearing, smell, taste and touch, which are retained accurately, but very briefly. For example, the ability to look for something and remember what it looked like with just a second of observation is an example of sensory memory.

The stimuli detected by our senses can either deliberately ignored, in which case they disappear almost instantaneously or perceived, in which case they enter our sensory memory. This does not require any conscious attention and, indeed, is usually considered to be totally outside of conscious control. The brain is designed to only process information that will be useful at later date, and to allow the rest to pass by unnoted. As information is perceived, it is therefore stored in sensory memory automatically and unbidden. Unlike other types of memory, the sensory cannot be prolonged via rehearsal.

Sensory memory is an ultra- short- term memory and decays or degrades very quickly, typically in the region of 200 – 500 milliseconds [$\frac{1}{5}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ second] after the perception of an item, and certainly less than a second.

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2. Short term memory – This acts as a kind of scratch – pad for temporary recall of the information which is being processed at any point in time, and has been referred to as ‘the brain’s post – it note’. It can be thought of as the ability to remember and process information at the same time. It holds a small amount of information [typically around 7 items or even less] in mind in an active, readily- available state for a

short period of time [typically from 10 to 15 seconds, or sometimes up to a minute].

3. Long term memory – Long time memory is, obviously enough, intended for storage of information over a long period of time. Despite our everyday impressions of forgetting, it seems likely that long term memory actually decays very little over time, and can store a seemingly unlimited amount of information almost indefinitely. Indeed, there is some debate as to whether it just becomes increasingly difficult to access or retrieve certain items from memory.

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Short term memory can become long term memory through the process of consolidation, involving rehearsal and meaningful association. Unlike short term memory (which relies mostly on an acoustic, and to a lesser extent a visual, code for storing information), long term memory encodes information for storage semantically (i.e. based on meaning and association). However, there is also evidence that long term memory does also encode to some extent by sound. For example, when we cannot quite remember a word but it is 'on the tip of the tongue', this is usually based on the sound of a word, not its meaning.

STRESS

Human beings at one point in time experienced high degree of sorrows, fears and other psychological discomfort as they interact in the environment. Some of these can be beneficial while others cannot. All these are accompanied by what we can termed as stress. Stress generally is regarded as when we feel that everything seems to have become too much i.e. we are overloaded and wonder whether we really

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can cope with the pressure placed upon us. Anything that poses a challenge or a threat to our well being is a stress.

Some stresses get you going and they are good for you – without any stress at all, many say our lives would be boring and would probably feel pointless. However, when the stress undermine both our mental and physical health, they are bad.

Stress can be thought of as any event that strains or exceeds an individual's ability to cope, Lazarus (1999). Leading causes of death and disability such as heart disease and stroke are almost certainly linked to stress. Stress can also be seen as the physical and mental response of the body to demands made upon it. It is the result of our reaction to outside events, not necessarily the events themselves. Not all stress is bad. We each function best and feel best at our optimal level of

physiological arousal. We need some stress to get everyday obligations done.

Stress can help if you need to work hard or react quickly. For example, it can help you win a race or finish an important job on time. But if stress happens too often or last too long, it can have bad effects.

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It can be linked to headache, stomach upset, back pain and trouble sleeping. It can make you moody, tense or depressed. Your relationships may suffer and you may not do well at work or school.

SOURCES OF STRESS

Most of sources of stress are obvious to us all – they rip and tear at our lives- but other sources of stress are quite surprising. The major sources of stress includes:

1. Life Events – Life events create stress and require adjustment and coping, Dohrenwend (2006), Monroe, Slavich, Torres and Gotlib (2007). Some of these life events can be positive or negative. So the negative life events are considered to be stressful.

a. Violence, war, and sexual assault- many studies document that being in a war (Pitman, 2006) and being the victim of a sexual assault or other violent crime are profoundly stressful experiences.

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b. Loss of a family member- the death of a spouse or a child can be tremendously stressful.

c. Natural disasters- this can be powerful stressful negative life events. People who in their lives experienced or witnessed earthquakes, tsunamis and other natural disasters tend to be more stressful.

d. Terrorism- this is another factor that can make people experience stress. Terroristic activities have of recent regarded as one of the most heneous crime perpetuated by some group of individuals for the purpose of achieving certain goals, for many years, people in many troubled parts of the world have had to cope with the stress of terroristic attacks most especially the Boko Haram saga.

e. Daily hassles – it is not surprising that major negative life events are stressful, but the small hassles of daily life are also important sources of stress. The pressures and work, getting a speeding ticket, loosing your glasses and countless other daily irritants can grate abrasively on mind and body.

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f. Positive life events - even positive life events can be stressful

under some circumstance. Factors associated with positive life events includes, the birth of a child, promotion in work place, college graduation and buying a new house etc. these make people to think positive, but they may require also stressful adjustment in patterns of living. People sometime are not aware of these life events that make them anxious and stressful.

2. Frustration - This results when people cannot satisfy their motives. You can see frustration in the face of a child who cannot reach the toy he dropped. When frustrations are serious, as in the case of unpaid workers who are denied raises, or when individuals experience the limits imposed by racial discrimination they can be a major source of stress.

3. Pressure - The term pressure is used to describe the stress that arises from threats of negative events. For example, in school, there is always the possibility that you will not perform well and you will fail. Some unhappy marriages are source of pressure because one spouse always seems to displease the other no

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matter how hard he or she tries to avoid it.

EFFECTS OF STRESS

Stress affect the individuals in many ways.

1. Physically - There is the presence of muscle tension that may bring about headaches, dizziness, insomnia. Also blood pressure may rise, fast breathing, dry mouth etc

2. Mentally - Stress can affect our thinking capacity. Thoughts may become confused. We may become preoccupied with problems. Individual find it harder to make decisions.

3. Emotionally - There is the problem of irritability, impatience, anger, frustration, fear, anxiety, self doubt, feelings of inadequacy, insecurity, hopelessness, unhappiness, emotional withdrawal and depressions.

4. Behaviourally - Stress may make people become less sociable, less caring, more hostile and insensitive to others. Risky behaviour is also associated with stress.

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MANAGING STRESS

In managing stress, the key to success is to think positively, take control of your stress and anxiety by learning effective techniques to it. Some ways of managing stress includes:

1. Looking after yourself - Be kind to yourself. Give yourself time in which you can choose what you want to do. Rest, do nothing, try a

relaxation technique, have a long hot bath, spend time with friends.

Eat well.

2. Confronting the problem – try to stand back and look at the problem carefully. Break it into manageable parts. Talk it through with someone else, brainstorm solutions or get help if you need it.

3. Find some distractions – sport and physical activity helps you to relax physically and also release endorphins in the body which produce a real feeling of wellbeing.

4. Express yourself – talking about it, write about it, shout about it.

Expressing your feelings can help to relieve stress. Acknowledging a problem to yourself and to others can be the

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first step in dealing with it.

5. Division of labour – try to delegate your responsibilities at work, or share them. If you make yourself indispensable, the likelihood of your feeling highly stressed is significantly greater.

6. Seek professional help – if the stress is affecting the way you function, go and see your doctor. Heightened stress for prolonged periods can be bad for your physical and mental health.

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